A sign of Honecker's mortality came on New Year's Eve 1982, when he was supposedly the target of an unsuccessful attempt on his life.

The drama began at 13.00 on the B109 – a Brandenburg country road – when a 41-year-old heating engineer, Paul Essling, tried to overtake the First Secretary's convoy. As the car neared the village of Klosterfelde, Essling cut in at high speed on Honecker's tail but a State Security vehicle managed to force the attacker's Lada off the road.

As he screeched to a halt, Essling jumped out of his car and fired shots from a 7.65mm Walther pistol, hitting a security official in the breastbone and lung. Seconds later, as two Secret Service agents raised their Kalashnikovs, Essling turned the gun on himself and fired a single shot to his head. Honecker, who was uninjured, remained crouched behind the passenger seat of his black Citroen.

Although it seems unlikely that the incident was a targeted assassination (Essling was drunk and had just had an argument with his girlfriend), FRG media caught wind of the story, prompting Stern's East Berlin correspondent, Dieter Bub, to claim the Stasi had instructed friends and relatives of Essling to remain silent; by this point however, half of Klosterfelde was gossiping about the incident. In a later article, Stern reported Essling had installed kitchens in Wandlitz and was appalled to discover, 'how members of the government and party officials lived in luxury'. Honecker made no statement after the incident, and the episode went unreported in GDR newspapers.2 After much speculation about events that day, the public prosecutor's office in Neuruppin concluded in 1995 that it had not been an attempted assassination.

Honecker privately enunciated this theory, never believing he would be the target of an assassin's gun.

That winter, the First Secretary underlined his message that the positioning of new US missiles in Western Europe could spark war on German territory. American nuclear deployment plans involved placing 464 cruise missiles – 160 in the United Kingdom, 112 in Italy, ninety-six in West Germany and forty-eight each in Belgium and Holland. In addition, 108 Pershing-2 weapons were due to be deployed in West Germany. 'Let no one forget: